

# ART AND CULTURE



## RELIGION AND PHILOSOPHY

### BHAKTI MOVEMENT

- IMPORTANT PHILOSOPHIES
- IMPORTANT PREACHERS

MODULE – 10





# EARLY BHAKTI MOVEMENT



ALVARS



NAYANARS

- The emergence of **Alvars** and **Nayanars** in South India marked the beginning of the Bhakti movement.
- It was a departure from the old religious thought process and **was more egalitarian and inclusive.**
- The salient features of the twin movements are discussed below.

# EARLY BHAKTI MOVEMENT

## THE ALVARS

- 1** The word Alvars literally means, **those immersed in devotion of Lord Vishnu**.
- 2** Their Bhakti tradition was characterized by penning of **songs and poems** in service and love of the God.
- 3** The saints and devotees would travel from place to place singing hymns in praise of Lord Vishnu or Krishna.
- 4** There were **12 important Alvars** who belonged to different social backgrounds, the best known being Periyalvar and his daughter Andal.
- 5** **Andal, the only woman Alvar saint**, wrote a number of compositions which are still sung to this day.
- 6** The **Nalayira Divya Prabandham** is an important Alvar composition.



# EARLY BHAKTI MOVEMENT

## THE NAYANARS



KARAIKKAL AMMAIYAR



SAMBANDAR, SUNDARAR, APPAR &  
MANIKKAVACHAKAR.

- 1 These were devotees of Lord Shiva who were a group of **63 saints** (also saint poets) in the 6th to 8th century.
- 2 Like Alvars, their mode of worship was **singing hymns** or devotional songs in praise of the deity and travel from place to place.
- 3 **Karaikkal Ammaiyar** was a female Shiva devotee whose compositions are preserved to this day.
- 4 The important Nayanars were **Sambandar, Sundarar, and Appar.**



# EARLY BHAKTI MOVEMENT

## THE NAYANARS



BRIHADISVARA TEMPLE, THANJAVUR



NATARAJA TEMPLE, CHIDAMBARAM

- 5 The compilation of their songs is contained in **Tevaram and Tiruvachakam**.
- 6 As a result of patronage of the Chola kings a number of temples of prominence dedicated to Lord Shiva were constructed at **Thanjavur, Chidambaram, and Gangaikondacholapuram**.
- 7 The Nayanar and Alvar traditions also inspired a number of splendid **metal and stone sculptures** (viz. the image of Shiva as Nataraja).



# EARLY BHAKTI MOVEMENT

## THE VIRASHAIVAS & THE LINGAYATS

- 1 The movement of Virashaiva (**heroes of Shiva**) or the Lingayats (**wearers of the Linga**) emerged in around 12<sup>th</sup> century in Karnataka.
- 2 The movement was started by **Basavana** (a Brahmin) who was earlier a Jaina and a minister in the court of a Chalukyan King.
- 3 The **Lingayats opposed the caste** system and worked for the emancipation of women and the downtrodden in the society.
- 4 They were **opposed to ritualism** and **Brahmanical orthodoxy**.
- 5 They supported widow remarriage and post puberty marriage of girls.
- 6 They did not believe in rebirth and believed in unification of the soul with Shiva on death.
- 7 Hence, they did not cremate their dead but buried them.
- 8 The teachings or the messages of the Lingayats is contained in Vachanas (literally meaning as sayings) which were composed in Kannada.



## EARLY BHAKTI MOVEMENT

### ARE VIRASHAIVAS AND LINGAYATS THE SAME?

| LINGAYAT                                                                                                                                  | VEERASHAIVAS                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Lingayats are followers of Basavanna, the 12th-century social reformer who rebelled against Hindu society and established a new dharma.   | Veerashaivism, as the name suggests, is an order of Shaiva faith, which in turn is one of the two major Vedic faiths – the other one being the Vaishnava faith. Both Shaiva and Vaishnava followers constitute the sanatana dharma. |
| Basavanna protested these practices like caste system, Vedic worship etc.                                                                 | They accept the Vedic texts and practices like caste and gender discrimination                                                                                                                                                      |
| But the Shiva that Basavanna referred to is not the Hindu mythological Shiva. Basavanna's Shiva is a formless, seamless figurative entity | Veerashaiva worship Lord Shiva, the one mentioned in Hindu mythology                                                                                                                                                                |
| In terms of religious practice, Basavanna propagated only the worship of Ishta Linga.                                                     | Basavanna had suggested wearing of the Ishtalinga on one's neck but Veerashaivas have done away with the practice                                                                                                                   |
| He did not encourage rituals and ceremonies of offering, prayer and sacrifice.                                                            | Veerashaivas, however, encourage such rituals in stark contrast.                                                                                                                                                                    |



# LATER BHAKTI MOVEMENT



- 1 While the first wave of Bhakti movement emerged from the southern part of India, it did not cover the entire country.
- 2 Further, no such parallel movement was seen in northern part of India for centuries to come.
- 3 Brahmins occupied important positions in the court of Rajput kings and discharged religious and secular functions.
- 4 Although some religious leaders did emerge from the non-Brahmanical background, viz. the Naths, the Jogis, and the Siddhas, it did not take the shape of a large scale movement.



## THE IMPACT OF THE DELHI SULTANATE AND THE ADVENT OF ISLAM

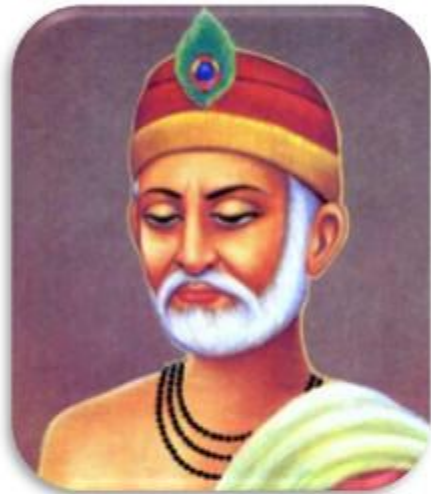
The advent of Islam and the establishment of Delhi sultanate had a profound impact on the Indian society in the following ways:

- 1** The Islamic religion with its **concept of equality and egalitarianism** also influenced the Hindu society, particularly the **marginalized section to whom the teachings of Islam appealed.**
- 2** The authority of the Rajputs and the socio-religious authority of the **Brahmins waned under the Delhi Sultanate.**
- 3** The influence of Islam also brought into fore the **Growth of Sufism.**
- 4** There was a **need for reform and consolidation of Hinduism** in the midst of sweeping socio-religious political changes, religious conversions, and turmoil in the mainstream Hindu religion.

***The above factors all led to the growth of the Bhakti movement.***



## THE IMPACT OF THE DELHI SULTANATE AND THE ADVENT OF ISLAM



KABIR DAS



GURU NANAK



SRI CHAITANYA

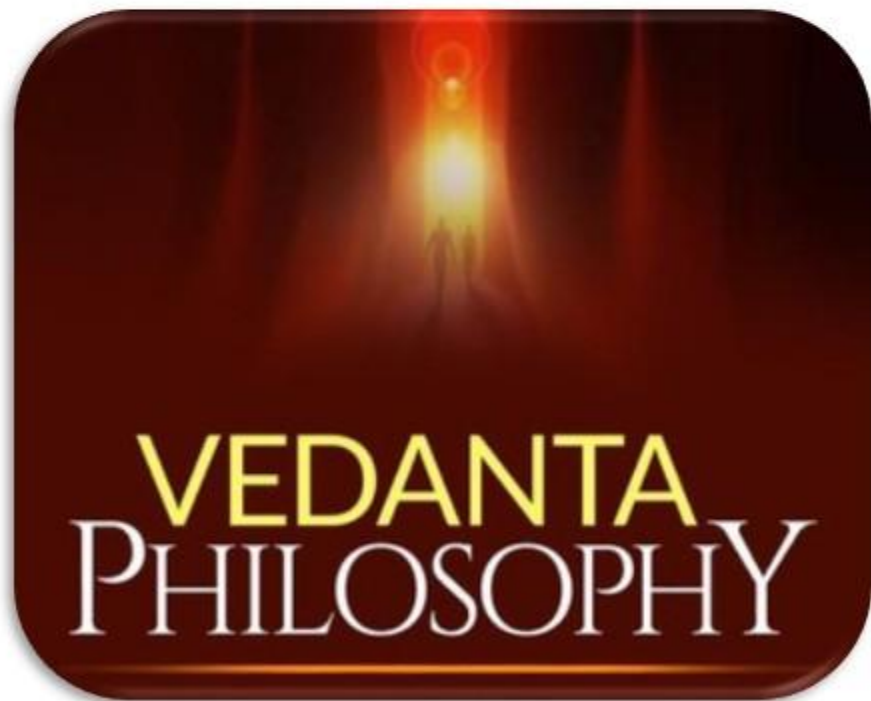
5 It is also noteworthy that the seeds of Bhakti movement were sowed in Upanishadic teachings and earlier revival in Hinduism brought about as a result of teachings and philosophy of **Shankaracharya** (Advaita-Vedanta philosophy), **Ramanuja** (Vishisht-Advaita philosophy), and **Madhavacharya** (Dvaitavad philosophy).

6 Thus, the later phase of Bhakti emerged in the 14<sup>th</sup> century CE and reached its peak in 15<sup>th</sup> and 16<sup>th</sup> century CE. It included many saints and preachers like **Ramananda**, **Kabir**, **Guru Nanak**, **Chaitanya**, **Mirabai**, etc.



## PHILOSOPHIES CHARACTERISING THE BHAKTI MOVEMENT

A number of philosophies are said to have influenced and characterized the Bhakti movement ranging from Vedantism to Sufism. Some of these are:



1

### Vedantism :

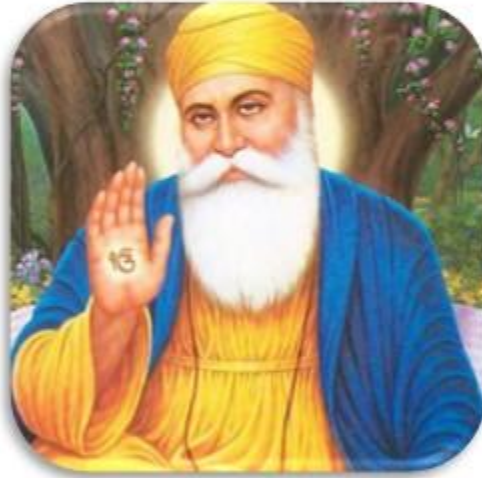
- The Upanishadic teaching particularly that of Shankaracharya, Madhavacharya, and Ramanuja has a salutary effect on **reformation of the Hindu religion and reducing the influence of ritualism and orthodoxy.**
- Thus, it paved the way for growth of Bhakti movement.



## PHILOSOPHIES CHARACTERISING THE BHAKTI MOVEMENT



KABIR DAS



GURU NANAK

2

### Dvaita and Advaita Philosophy :

- Bhakti movement incorporated in its fold both the Advait philosophy or monism and the Dvaita philosophy or dualism.
- Elements of both philosophies can be found in teaching of Bhakti saints.
- While that of Nanak's and Kabir's philosophy were based on monism, many other Bhakti teachers preached the dualistic philosophy.



## PHILOSOPHIES CHARACTERISING THE BHAKTI MOVEMENT

### 3 Nirguna and Saguna :

- Bhakti movement also saw emergence of two distinct streams of devotion, the **Nirguna** or those who believed in formless and attributeless God; and **Saguna** where God was perceived to be having attributes and was even personalized.
- While some preachers like Kabir believed in a formless God (Nirguna Brahma), the likes of Mirabai, Tulsidas, and Soordas were devotees of the Saguna Brahma.

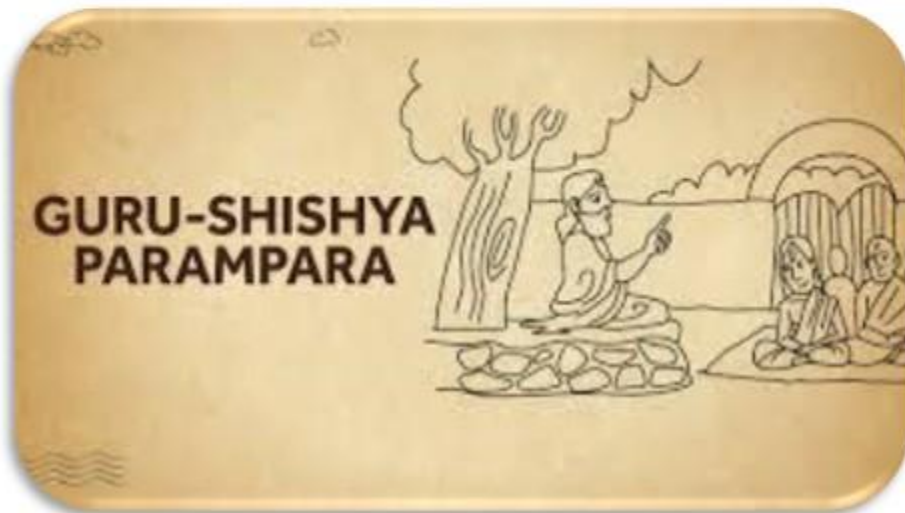
### 4 Sufism :

- This too had an important influence on Hindu society, **particularly its emphasis on unity of God and equality of mankind.**
- Sufism and its growth is also seen by scholars to be often parallel to the Bhakti movement.



## FEATURES OF THE BHAKTI MOVEMENT

- 1 The movement emphasized on **Bhakti (or devotion to God)** as a means to attain salvation.
- 2 The movement and most preachers emphasized on **monotheism** or existence of one God.
- 3 However, the perception of God could be **Nirguna** (formless/attributeless) or **Saguna** (with attributes).
- 4 The movement emphasized on **equality of mankind and was inclusive**. It professed salvation to women and the marginalized.
- 5 It **dispensed the need of rituals, attacked dogmas, Brahmanical superiority**, and prescribed surrender to God through bhakti as means of salvation.
- 6 It preached mostly in **local language** and followed **the guru-shishya tradition**.





# IMPORTANT PREACHERS IN THE BHAKTI MOVEMENT

1

SHANKARACHARYA

8<sup>th</sup> century CE; Preached throughout India.



- Also referred as Adi Shankaracharya, he was responsible for bringing revival and reformation in Hinduism.
- His teachings are based on **Advaita philosophy of Vedanta (monism)** emphasizing on the unity of the creator and creation.
- Founded the **four 'mathas'** in different geographical locations of the country and thus unifying Hinduism.
- Laid the foundation of Bhakti movement with his composition of devotional hymns in praise of Lord Vishnu, Lord Shiva, and goddess Shakti.
- Composed commentaries on the Vedas (Brahma Sutras), Upanishads, and the Gita.



# IMPORTANT PREACHERS IN THE BHAKTI MOVEMENT

2

RAMANUJA

11<sup>th</sup> century CE; Tamil Nadu and South India



RAMANUJA

- He was the **propounder of the Vishishtadvaita philosophy**. Along with Advaita Philosophy (of Shankaracharya) and Dvaita philosophy (of Madhavacharya), the three form the most important Vedantic philosophy
- Follower of Sri Vaishnavism (worship of Vishnu and Lakshmi)
- Teachings emphasized on Bhakti or devotion to a personal God.



# IMPORTANT PREACHERS IN THE BHAKTI MOVEMENT

3

BASAVANNA

12<sup>th</sup> century CE; Karnataka



- He was philosopher, a Kannada poet, a statesman, and a religious reformer
- Laid the foundation of **Lingayat sect** which emphasized on devotion to Lord Shiva (**followers wore Shivalinga around neck**).
- He spread **social awareness** through his poetry which is known as **Vachanas**.
- Compilation of the Vachanas is called **Vachana Sahitya**.

# IMPORTANT PREACHERS IN THE BHAKTI MOVEMENT

3

BASAVANNA

12<sup>th</sup> century CE; Karnataka



- He introduced new public institutions such as the **Anubhava Mantapa** (or, the "hall of spiritual experience"), which welcomed men and women from all socio-economic backgrounds to discuss spiritual and mundane questions of life, in open.
- The **Basavarajadevara Ragale** by the Kannada poet **Harihara** is the earliest available account on the life of the social reformer.



# IMPORTANT PREACHERS IN THE BHAKTI MOVEMENT

4

MADHAVACHARYA

13<sup>th</sup> century CE; Karnataka



- Propounded the **Dvaita** philosophy of **Vedanta** which emphasized on dualism or **subtle but fundamental difference** between the **Brahma** (creator) and **Atman** (soul)
- Emphasized on attaining salvation through the **grace of God** through the **Bhakti** tradition.
- Composed nearly 37 texts on Dvaita philosophy.

WE EXPRESS OUR  
SINCERE THANKS  
FOR VIEWING THIS VIDEO

Presented by



Learning Space

For Suggestions:

[suggestions@learningspace.in](mailto:suggestions@learningspace.in)

To Contact us:

[info@learningspace.in](mailto:info@learningspace.in)

OUR TEAM

G. V. Rao  
K. Srikanth  
D. Sunil Kumar  
L. V. Krishna  
Y. Deepthi

Amrita Naidu  
M. Binukrishna  
G. Ravi Babu  
D. Joji  
K. Victor Babu

Visit us at:

[www.learningspacedigital.com](http://www.learningspacedigital.com)

0 8 6 6 -2 4 4 4 4 7 2  
0 9 8 4 9 9 4 2 2 9 9